

Open Knowledge for a Sustainable Future: Research, Ethics, and Wikipedia

Week 3 — Academic Style & Evaluating Sources

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Contents

- 1 Why should we write?
- 2 What is your message?
- 3 How can you convince people?
- 4 In class: reading each other's writing
- 5 What are good sources?
- 6 How can I make it easy for my reader?

Roadmap

- 1 Why should we write?
 - Reading for Writing
- 2 What is your message?
- 3 How can you convince people?
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Purpose of Writing in the Humanities and Social Sciences

- Writing is both a **tool for thinking** and a **means of communication**.
- It helps clarify ideas, interpret texts, and contribute to scholarly conversations.
- Written work demonstrates:
 - ▶ Understanding of key issues
 - ▶ Ability to argue persuasively
 - ▶ Awareness of disciplinary methods
- Writing is a process of *inquiry and reflection*, not merely reporting.
- Aim: to explore questions, not just provide answers.

Partly based on [Analyzing Texts, Taking Notes](#) (Allosso & Allosso, 2019, Ch. 1)

Humanities, Social Sciences, and Linguistics

- All three analyze human experience, culture, society, *and* language.
- **Humanities:**
 - ▶ Interpret texts, artworks, languages, and histories.
 - ▶ Value close reading, interpretation, argumentation.
- **Social Sciences:**
 - ▶ Study human behavior, institutions, and systems.
 - ▶ Employ observation, evidence, and models.
- **Linguistics:** (bridging H/SS; both theoretical and empirical)
 - ▶ *General:* structure and use of language
 - ▶ *Variation & change:* sociolinguistics, dialectology, historical linguistics.
 - ▶ *Mind & processing:* psycholinguistics, neurolinguistics.
 - ▶ *Data & methods:* corpora, fieldwork/elicitation, experiments, formal modeling.
 - ▶ *Technology & applications:* computational linguistics/NLP, lexicography, language documentation.
- Despite differences, all rely on:
 - ▶ Critical analysis and evidence-based reasoning
 - ▶ Clear written communication tailored to audience and genre

Writing as Inquiry

- Writing helps generate ideas and refine questions.
- Early drafts explore possibilities rather than finalize conclusions.
- Revision is discovery: each draft deepens understanding.
- Effective writers balance:
 - ▶ **Open exploration** with
 - ▶ **Focused argumentation.**
- Thinking happens through writing, not before it.

Academic Conversations

- Academic writing joins an ongoing **conversation of ideas**.
- You engage with others by:
 - ▶ Quoting and analyzing sources
 - ▶ Summarizing and synthesizing prior work
 - ▶ Acknowledging different viewpoints
- Essays must both *respond to* and *extend* these discussions.
- Citations show respect for others' intellectual labor.
- Every essay adds a new voice to the dialogue.

Voice and Style

- Academic writing has a clear, confident voice.
- Strive for:
 - ▶ Precision over ornamentation
 - ▶ Clarity over complexity
 - ▶ Variety in sentence structure
- Avoid jargon unless necessary.
- Use active verbs and concise phrasing.
- Revision improves tone and flow.
- Essays need logical progression of ideas.
 - ▶ Use outlines to maintain focus.
 - ▶ Ensure every section supports the thesis.

Revising and Editing

- Revision refines both ideas and expression.
- Strategies:
 - ▶ Read aloud to test clarity
 - ▶ Seek peer or instructor feedback
 - ▶ Review argument flow
 - ▶ Cut redundancy
- Editing focuses on grammar, punctuation, and formatting.
- Always proofread before submission.

Academic Integrity

- Uphold honesty in research and writing.
- Avoid plagiarism by citing all borrowed ideas.
- Keep detailed notes on sources.
- Paraphrase thoughtfully; don't just reword sentences.
- Academic trust depends on intellectual transparency.

Reading for Writing

- Treat writing as a **thinking process** that begins with reading and note-taking.
- Approach every lecture, discussion, and reading as a **text** to analyze.
- Ask questions continually; **do not read passively**.
- Build habits that connect reading notes to future **essay arguments**.
- Aim to understand *how* a “verbal contraption” works, not just what it says.

Partly based on [Analyzing Texts, Taking Notes](#) (Allosso & Allosso, 2019, Ch. 1)

What Counts as a “Text”?

- Any statement encountered in class: readings, **lectures**, prepared discussions.
- Analyze texts **all the time**, not only when told to.
- Compare new material with prior readings, lectures, and beliefs.
- Write thoughts down—notes become the **foundation** of essays.
- Focus on both **content** and **method**: what it says and how it works.

- Break the text into parts to see **purpose** and **mechanism**.
- Notice use of plot, imagery, symbolism, allusion (not just in literature).
- Recognize that nonfiction also deploys **language tools** strategically.
- Read to discover **patterns**, not only to collect facts.
- Remember: analyzing others' writing prepares you to **write interpretively**.

General Questions to Drive Analysis

- What confuses you? What needs **clarification**?
- Which claims are most **central** to the text's project?
- How do structure and language **support** those claims?
- What assumptions or **premises** are in play?
- How does this text relate to other course materials and **your concerns**?

For Fiction (Mostly)

- **Narrator:** who tells the story? reliable/unreliable/biased?
- **Setting & tone:** what senses and emotions are evoked?
- **Characters:** motivations, alignments, identification cues.
- **Language/diction:** level and implications.
- **Plot/structure:** problems, challenges, archetypes.
- **Images/motifs:** repetitions, metaphors, patterns.
- **Ending:** what resolves? why end *there*?

For Nonfiction (Mostly)

- **Author:** background and qualifications.
- **Audience:** allies, opponents, or neutral readers?
- **Intention:** explanatory, polemical, celebratory—*why* written?
- **Structure:** how is the argument organized?
- **Appeals:** logic vs. emotion; what types of arguments are used?

On Arguments: Classical Roots

- Aristotle analyzed features of argument still relevant today.
- Logic is central to many, but not all, arguments.
- A **syllogism** shows how accepted premises force a conclusion.
- Recognize that not all premises are **incontrovertible**.
- Much real-world reasoning yields **probable** rather than absolute conclusions.

Deduction (Syllogism) in Brief

- Moves from accepted premises to a **necessary** conclusion.
- If premises hold, disputing the conclusion is **illogical**.
- Useful when shared facts/definitions exist.
- Limits: debates often target the **premises** themselves.
- Practice: state premises explicitly; test their **soundness**.

- Starts from observations/data and infers a **generalization**.
- Conclusions are **tentative** (we never observe everything).
- Science frames even strong theories as **revisable**.
- Good induction “**follows the data.**”
- Beware overreach; match claim strength to **evidence**.

Narrative as Argument

- Stories and anecdotes can **persuade** by identification.
- History blends data, concepts, and **narrative structure**.
- Narrative can sometimes substitute for data or axioms.
- The most powerful stories **engage emotion**.
- Ask why a writer turns to story—what **work** is narrative doing?

Reason, Emotion, and Premises

- Distinguish appeals to **reason** vs. **emotion**.
- Identify the trail from premises to conclusion.
- Test premises for **assumptions**, generality, and evidence.
- Map where uncertainty lies: data, inference, or **values**.
- Use your notes to plan a balanced, **well-supported** response.

Quick Note-Taking Checklist

- Capture **central question** and main claims.
- Mark **evidence** and how it supports claims.
- Flag **key terms**, metaphors, and recurring motifs.
- Record **questions** and possible counterarguments.
- Synthesize into a **one–two sentence** takeaway for future drafting.

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What Is a Thesis?

- A thesis is a claim that can be **defended with reasons and evidence**.
- It is neither a topic nor a fact, but an **interpretation**.
- Example:
 - ▶ Topic: “Women in Shakespeare.”
 - ▶ Thesis: “Shakespeare’s comedies use disguise to challenge gender norms.”
- A thesis makes a promise to the reader about the essay’s direction.

From Question to Argument

- Start with a genuine **question or problem**.
- Narrow broad curiosity into a focused inquiry.
- Ask “*How? Why? So what?*” about your topic.
- As you read and write, your tentative answer becomes a **working thesis**.
- Revise the thesis as new evidence appears.

Characteristics of a Strong Thesis

- **Debatable:** reasonable people could disagree
- **Specific:** not a vague generality
- **Focused:** answerable in the space you have
- **Insightful:** says something not already obvious
- **Connected:** matches the evidence you actually have

Weak — announces a topic

“This essay will discuss social media and teenagers.”

“This essay will discuss data centres and water.”

Strong — takes a stance

“Social media intensifies teenage anxiety by rewarding performative identity.”

“Data centre water use is small nationally but heavy locally, so it should be reported by watershed.”

A strong thesis makes the reader ask **how?** and **why?**

Refining Your Thesis

- Expect early theses to be **rough hypotheses**.
- Strengthen by:
 - ▶ Clarifying key terms.
 - ▶ Tightening scope.
 - ▶ Checking consistency with evidence.
- Ask peers to summarize your claim—does it match your intent?
 - ▶ **That is what we are about to do with your water paragraphs.**
- Revision turns a statement into a compelling argument.

Common Pitfalls

- Thesis too **broad** or too **narrow**.
- Merely **summarizes** instead of analyzing.
- Contains **multiple, unconnected** claims.
- Uses vague verbs: “shows,” “is about,” “explores.”
- Fails to anticipate **counterarguments**.

Purpose and Tone Across Disciplines

Humanities	Persuasive, interpretive, argument-driven. Focus on ideas and textual evidence.
Social Sciences	Empirical, objective tone. Focus on testing hypotheses, describing data.
Linguistics	Analytical, combining theory and data. Balances conceptual framing with empirical evidence.
Computer Science	Technical, concise, performance-oriented. Emphasis on algorithms, models, evaluation metrics.

How Arguments Are Built

- **Humanities:** logic of persuasion → evidence supports an interpretation.
- **Social Sciences:** logic of proof → evidence tests a hypothesis.
- **Linguistics:** logic of demonstration → evidence shows a pattern or contrast.
- **Computer Science:** logic of replication → results must be reproducible.
- **All:** aim for clarity, coherence, and a sense of contribution.

Encyclopedic Writing: Wikipedia Style

- **Purpose:** inform, not argue — summarize accepted knowledge.

- **Tone:** neutral, verifiable, non-original.

- **Structure:** topic-based, not narrative.

Overview → Subtopics → References.

Lead → Body → Appendices

[Wikipedia:Manual of Style/Layout](#)

- **Comparison:**

- ▶ Unlike research writing, no new data or interpretation.
- ▶ Like the introduction of an academic paper, it provides context and key sources.
- ▶ Ideal for background reading, not for advancing claims.

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From Topic to Argument

- Move from gathering ideas to **building a case**.
- Prefer **logical** appeals; use emotion sparingly and purposefully.
- Choose modes of reasoning suited to your materials.
- Keep conclusions **tentative yet confident**—acknowledge limits.
- Let structure make your thinking **followable** for readers.

Partly based on [Ordering Evidence, Building an Argument](#) (Allosso & Allosso, 2019, Ch. 4)

Worry about the structure more than the style

Prose is architecture, not interior decoration, and the Baroque is over.
Ernest Hemingway (1932) *Death in the afternoon*

- Build on a **solid foundation**: thesis and linked reasons.
- **Form follows function**: structure should serve clarity.
- Mechanical scaffolding may be invisible, but must exist.
- Avoid random piles of points; design for **coherence**.

Outline: Before or After Drafting

- Two approaches
 - A sketch a **pre-outline** of controlling ideas (topic sentences).
 - B **draft first**, then reverse-outline to reveal logic.
- Either way, ensure the essay is **going somewhere**, not circling.
- Expect to **add/subtract/rearrange**—everything is tentative mid-process.
- Use outlines to test **progression** and **balance**.
- I [FCB] normally write an outline and collect notes as I go along, then write prose at the end. I write a rough introduction first, but revise it at the end, as I almost always change many details, ...

The Working Model (Intro–Body–Conclusion)

- **Introduction:** hook interest; give only necessary context; state thesis.
- **Body:** organize supporting ideas into coherent paragraphs.
- **Transitions:** create **meaningful** links, avoid monotony.
- **Support:** back each assertion with **textual or data** evidence.
- **Conclusion:** reconnect claims; answer “*so what?*”; mirror the intro.

Paragraphs as Structural Beams

- Each paragraph advances **one** controlling idea.
- Start with a **topic sentence** tied to the thesis.
- Develop with **evidence + analysis**, not lists of facts.
- End by **linking forward** to the next step in the argument.
- Trim digressions; keep the **load-bearing** path visible.

Audience and Explicitness

- Define key terms; avoid assuming shared premises.
- Make **premises** and **purposes** explicit.
- Explain why evidence is **relevant**, not just that it exists.
- Balance brevity with the reader's need for **orientation**.
- Prefer **readability** over flourish: clarity persuades.

What you should aim for

- **Logical sequence**; momentum without stalls.
- **Smooth transitions**; visible through-line from thesis to conclusion.
- Claims **properly supported**; no orphan generalizations.
 - ▶ Reliable sources clearly and correctly cited
- Overall emphasis aligns with the essay's **central question**.

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In class: read each other's paragraphs

You each read the same three texts on water use in data centres, and wrote three paragraphs. Now swap with the person next to you.

- **Read it once without writing anything** 5 min
- **Then answer four questions on the worksheet** 10 min
 - ① What is this writer's **claim**? One sentence, in your own words.
 - ② Which text did they **trust most**, and on what grounds?
 - ③ Do you agree with their **judgement of the sources**?
 - ④ Do you agree with their **conclusion** about water?
- **Talk in pairs** — start with question 1, and let the writer say whether that is what they meant 10 min

Useful feedback is specific: point at a sentence. “I disagree” is not feedback; “your second paragraph claims X, but the source you cite says Y” is. (worksheet also on the course website)

Questions 3 and 4 are not the same question

- You can think a text is **well evidenced** and still think its **conclusion** is wrong
- You can agree with a conclusion that rests on **nothing**
- Keeping those apart is the whole job:
 - ▶ it is what a peer reviewer does in December
 - ▶ it is what **neutral point of view** asks of you on Wikipedia: report what the sources say, whatever you think of it

Watch for this in your answers: Masley says data centres use 0.008% of US fresh water. Mytton (2021) and the Wikipedia article talk about stress on *particular* watersheds. Neither is lying. They chose different things to compare against — and that choice does most of the persuading.

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Judging a source: the source itself

Ask	You want	Worry if
Who wrote it?	a named author with findable credentials in <i>this</i> field	anonymous, or an expert in something else
Who published it?	a journal or press with editors and review	an advocacy group, a content farm, no editorial trail
When?	recent enough for how fast the field moves	stale — or retracted
Why was it made?	to report or explain	to sell, to lobby, to entertain

Check retractions in the [Retraction Watch Database](#) — by title, DOI, author or journal. It also tells you *why* a paper was withdrawn.

Judging a source: its argument

Ask	You want	Worry if
What is the evidence?	data, examples, citations you can follow	assertions with nothing behind them
Who is missing?	it engages work that disagrees with it	it cites mostly itself and its friends
How is it worded?	measured; states its own limits	loaded words; inconvenient evidence left out
Does it help you?	it supports or challenges <i>your</i> claim	it is there to make the bibliography look longer

No source is neutral. Naming the slant is the work; pretending it is not there is the mistake. Evaluation is judgement, not a checklist.

What kind of source is it?

How close to the thing itself

- **Primary:** the data, the text, the interview, the law
- **Secondary:** analysis and interpretation of those
- **Tertiary:** overviews — textbooks, encyclopedias, **Wikipedia**

- Use primary for evidence, secondary for framing, tertiary to find your way in
- Wikipedia is where you **start**, not what you **cite** — follow its references to the real sources

Who it was written for

- **Scholarly:** peer-reviewed, technical, referenced
- **Popular:** journalism, written to be read over breakfast
- **Grey:** reports from governments, NGOs, companies — often excellent, rarely reviewed

The Role of Peer Review

- Peer review adds accountability and expert evaluation.
- Check the journal's own website, or one of these, for peer-review status:
 - ▶ [DOAJ](#): free; open-access journals, with their review policy listed
 - ▶ [Scopus Sources](#), [Web of Science Master Journal List](#), [Ulrichsweb](#) (look for *Refereed: Yes*)
— these need a subscription: reach them through the university library, not from home
- Conference papers, reports, and blogs may lack external review.
- Non-reviewed sources can still inform background reading—use carefully.
- Note review processes in your evaluation notes.
 - ▶ **Single-blind**: reviewer knows author
 - ▶ **Double-blind**: neither reviewer nor author knows the other's identity
 - ▶ How many reviewers?

Synthesizing Multiple Sources

- Evaluation continues through comparison.
- Ask:
 - ▶ How do sources agree or conflict?
 - ▶ Which are most authoritative or current?
- Synthesis reveals gaps and consensus in the field.
- Use evaluation to decide which sources to highlight or challenge.

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Make the Information Accessible

-  **Identify the source clearly:** include author, year, title, publisher, and version or edition.
-  **Pinpoint the exact location:** add chapter, section, or page number — especially for long works.
-  **Help readers find it quickly:** provide a persistent link (URL, DOI) or unique identifier (ISBN, dataset ID).
-  **Be consistent:** use one style throughout — in this course, **APA 7**.

Avoid Formatting or Mechanics Errors — Why It Matters

- Formal citation styles encode a “**secret code**”
—tiny details convey location and source type.
- Using the community’s preferred style is a “**secret handshake**”: it signals you know the insider code.
- Attention to detail builds **credibility** with readers who value intellectual property and accuracy.
- Even in an era of easy keyword search, conventions still help readers **find and verify** sources quickly.
- Goal: demonstrate care and competence, not just avoid penalties.
 - ▶ You should use software to help

Pick the Right Style & Identify Source Type

- Different communities prefer different styles: **APA** (most social sciences), **MLA** (literature), **Chicago** (notes-bibliography, or author–date).
 - ▶ **For your paper in this course: APA 7.** Examples on [the course website](#).
- Determine what you're citing:
 - ▶ Book vs. journal article vs. whole website vs. a single post/section.
 - ▶ Each type has **slightly different** required elements and order.
- Differences usually make sense: books have titles/pages; tweets usually do not.
- Match the pattern to the **actual source features**.
- Avoid adding **unnecessary information**.

Consistency is Non-Negotiable

- Pick a style and **stay with it**—don't mix conventions.
- If you sometimes include the year and sometimes don't, readers may suspect **incomplete acknowledgment**.
- For unusual sources (e.g., a deleted TikTok under a pseudonym), imitate the **closest established pattern**.
- Prioritize reader orientation: can they **find** what you cited?
- Keep a short **personal checklist** to enforce uniformity.

Tools Help—But You're Still Responsible

- Bibliography managers and library export tools can **misformat** elements.
 - ▶ E.g. Nuril Hirfana binte Mohamed Noor, Suerya binte Sapuan and Francis Bond (2011) cite as Nuril Hirfana, Suerya and Bond (2011)
- You must still **proofread** citations against the style rules.
- Learn enough of the code to **spot errors** quickly.
- Online forms may omit fields or guess wrong—**verify** and fill gaps.
- Working in a “**generation gap**” means tools + human judgment are both needed.

Don't worry too much!

- No one is born knowing citation mechanics; even strong writers make mistakes.
- The most important thing is that people can find the information.
- Errors **do not** imply bad faith—but accuracy **does** build trust.
- Getting the details right gives you **credibility**.
- Over time, you join the discourse community that **evolves** conventions.
- Learn the secret handshake, but most importantly **help readers** locate the sources.

Citing Works Not in English

- Scholarly writing often involves **sources in other languages**.
- Goals:
 - ▶ Give credit to the original author.
 - ▶ Help readers identify the work (even if they don't read the language).
 - ▶ Follow your citation style's rules for **non-English titles**.
- APA and most citation systems recommend:
 - ▶ Keeping the original title in the source language.
 - ▶ Optionally providing an **English translation in brackets**.
- Transliterate non-Latin scripts if possible; retain diacritics accurately.

General Principles (APA / biblatex)

- Use the author's name in the script of publication (APA allows Latin transliteration).
- Give publication data exactly as printed (year, publisher). APA 7 dropped the publisher's location.
- If the reader is unlikely to understand the title:
 - ▶ Add a translation in square brackets, outside the italics: *Válka s Mloky* [War with the Newts].
- Don't invent English titles — translate accurately but informally.
- If the work has an official English edition, you may cite that instead or alongside.

Example: Czech Source (Čapek, 1936)

```
@book{capek1936,  
  author    = {Čapek, Karel},  
  year      = {1936},  
  title     = {Válka s Mloky [War with the Newts]},  
  publisher = {Fr. Borový},  
  langid    = {czech}  
}
```

Text citation examples:

- Čapek (1936) satirizes industrial modernity through the figure of the salamander.
- The allegory of human exploitation appears early in the narrative (Čapek, 1936).

References entry (APA style):

Čapek, K. (1936). Válka s Mloky [War with the Newts]. Fr. Borový.

No place of publication: APA 7 dropped it. Put the translation in the `title` field — biblatex has a `titleaddon` field, but this style brackets it for you, so typing your own brackets there gives you two sets.

Example: Japanese Source (芥川龍之介, 1918)

```
@article{akutagawa1918,  
  author = {芥川龍之介},      sortname = {Akutagawa, Ryūnosuke},  
  year = {1918},  
  title = {蜘蛛の糸 Kumo no ito [The Spider's Thread]},  
  journaltitle = {赤い鳥 Akai Tori},  
  volume = {1}, number = {1},  
  langid = {japanese}}
```

Text citation examples:

- 芥川龍之介 (1918) retells a Buddhist parable of redemption and failure.
- Compassion and egoism intertwine in 「蜘蛛の糸」 (芥川龍之介, 1918).

References entry (APA 7):

芥川龍之介 [Akutagawa, R.]. (1918). 蜘蛛の糸 *Kumo no ito [The spider's thread]*. 赤い鳥 *Akai Tori*, 1(1).

When to Translate or Transliterate

- If the audience reads the language → keep original title only.
- If not → add translation in brackets after the original title.
- Transliteration (romaji, pinyin, etc.) helps with alphabetization and search.
- Example (Japanese romanization):
Akutagawa, Ryūnosuke. (1918). Kumo no ito [The spider's thread].
- Always apply one consistent pattern for all non-English items.

Acknowledgements I

- The first sections were based on A Short Handbook for Writing Essays in the Humanities and Social Sciences (Allosso & Allosso, 2019)
- I also consulted Reid (2024) and Krause (2007)
- OpenAI (2025) was used to format the references, and generate a first draft of the slides with a prompt like

Please make me some slides, based on Chapter 1:

<https://mlpp.pressbooks.pub/writinghandbook/chapter/chapter-1/>

Make them in LaTeX, using luatex and biber, please make around 15 slides with at least 5 bullet points, use sub-lists where appropriate.

- **Claude Opus 5** (Anthropic, 2026) was used to check the slides rather than to write them: to resolve every DOI against Crossref, fetch every URL, and compare each quotation with its original. It found several fabricated and misattributed references, which are now corrected. The prompt was of the form

Acknowledgements II

Verify every claim, DOI, URL and quotation against a real source. Where you cannot verify something, say so rather than guessing --- never invent a reference.

Each correction names the source it was checked against. Responsibility for what remains is mine.

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These frames repeat material covered in the first week, or covered more fully later in this deck. They are here for reference.

Evaluating Sources — Why It Matters

- Academic writing depends on **credible evidence**.
- Poor sources weaken even the best reasoning.
- Evaluating sources ensures:
 - ▶ Accuracy and reliability
 - ▶ Awareness of bias and limits
 - ▶ Relevance to your argument
- Evaluation is a **critical thinking skill**, not a checklist exercise.

Adapted from [Evaluating Sources](#) (WAC Clearinghouse, Colorado State University).

Purpose and Audience

- Ask: Why was this text created? For whom?
- Purposes may include:
 - ▶ Informing or teaching
 - ▶ Persuading or advocating
 - ▶ Selling or entertaining
- Identify intended audience: scholars, professionals, or the general public.
- Match the source's aim with your own research goal.

Author and Authority

- Who is the author, and what makes them credible?
- Check:
 - ▶ Education and institutional affiliation
 - ▶ Prior publications and expertise
 - ▶ Reputation in the field
- Anonymous or uncredentialed authors demand extra scrutiny.
- Authority may also stem from collective or institutional authorship.

- Who publishes or hosts the source?
- University presses and peer-reviewed journals usually signal quality control.
- For websites, assess the domain and hosting organization.
- Recognize potential **institutional bias** in think tanks, corporations, or advocacy groups.
- Prefer sources with transparent editorial oversight.

Currency and Timeliness

- Consider when the source was written or updated.
- In fast-moving fields, information may age quickly.
- For historical or theoretical work, older sources may remain foundational.
- Look for revision dates, update logs, or newer editions.
- Always relate publication date to your topic's context.
- Has the paper been **retracted**?
 - ▶ Search in the official [Retraction Watch Database](#)
 - ▶ Run a search by title, DOI, author, or journal.
 - ▶ This is the most comprehensive open database of retracted papers, maintained by Retraction Watch and made openly available through Crossref.
 - ▶ It also notes the reason for retraction (e.g., plagiarism, data falsification, honest error).

Evidence and Support

- Reliable sources **show their work**.
- Ask:
 - ▶ What kinds of evidence are used? (data, quotations, examples)
 - ▶ Are sources cited and traceable?
 - ▶ Is reasoning logical and transparent?
- Unsupported claims or missing citations signal weakness.
- Cross-check evidence against other reputable works.
 - ▶ Multiple sources are more reliable

Bias and Objectivity

- No source is completely neutral.
- Look for:
 - ▶ Loaded language or emotional tone
 - ▶ Selective omission of evidence
 - ▶ Conflicts of interest or funding ties
- Identify perspective; judge how it shapes interpretation.
- Acknowledge bias rather than ignoring it.

Balance and Completeness

- Does the source present multiple viewpoints fairly?
- Recognize one-sided or partial presentations.
 - ▶ If they cite mostly themselves it is a bad sign (what counts as “too much” varies a lot by field)
 - ▶ If they only cite their colleagues it is a bad sign
- Check whether evidence contradicting the claim is addressed.
- Balanced sources strengthen your own credibility when cited.
- Even biased sources can be useful if analyzed critically.

Relevance to Your Project

- Determine how the source connects to your research question.
- Directly relevant sources:
 - ▶ Support or challenge your thesis
 - ▶ Provide key evidence or theory
- Peripheral sources may supply context or background.
- Avoid citing tangential material to inflate your bibliography.

Primary vs. Secondary Sources

- **Primary:** original materials (texts, data, interviews, artifacts).
- **Secondary:** analysis, interpretation, commentary.
- **Tertiary:** index or textual consolidation of primary and secondary sources
- Choose according to purpose:
 - ▶ Primary for direct evidence
 - ▶ Secondary for framing and critique
 - ▶ Tertiary for an overview
- Distinguish between firsthand and filtered perspectives.

Scholarly vs. Popular Sources

- **Scholarly:** peer-reviewed, technical, detailed references.
- **Popular:** general readership, journalistic style.
- Use scholarly works for evidence, popular for public context.
- Be cautious: some “grey literature” mixes the two.
- Evaluate tone, citations, and rigor to tell them apart.

Checklist for Evaluating a Source

- Purpose and audience clearly stated?
- Author's credentials and affiliations verifiable?
- Publisher or host credible and transparent?
- Evidence traceable and balanced?
- Date current enough for the topic?
- Bias recognized and context considered?
- Source relevant to your own argument?

Finding Building Blocks

- Gather: **facts, quotations, data, prior interpretations.**
- Note how each item **functions** (example, counterexample, definition).
- Separate **summary** from **analysis** in notes.
- Track source details for citation and revisiting.
- Prune items that don't advance the **central claim.**

Sequencing and Emphasis

- Order points to create **momentum** (e.g., simple → complex).
- Front-load definitions; defer **nuances** until foundations are set.
- Place your strongest section where it has **maximum impact**.
- Use headings and transitions to signal **hierarchy** and shifts.
- Revisit sequence after drafting; **reshuffle** if clarity improves.

Developing a Thesis — Chapter Overview

- The **thesis statement** is the backbone of any essay.
- It defines the argument and gives shape to analysis and evidence.
- A good thesis emerges from **questioning**, not from mere assertion.
- Writing itself helps **discover** the thesis.
- The thesis evolves through **drafting and revision**.

Partly based on [Creating a Thesis](#) (Allosso & Allosso, 2019, Ch. 3)

Thesis as a Map for the Reader

- The thesis signals what evidence matters.
- Each paragraph should support or test part of the claim.
- Readers use it to navigate your logic.
- Keep it visible—state it early and restate (refined) in the conclusion.
- Avoid burying the thesis in background or description.

Types of Thesis Statements

- **Analytical:** interprets and explains evidence. (e.g., “The novel critiques capitalism through its fragmented narration.”)
- **Expository:** explains a concept or process. (useful for background essays)
- **Argumentative:** takes a position and justifies it. (most common in humanities writing)
- Choose type according to essay’s purpose.

Summary & Takeaway

- A strong thesis:
 - ▶ Arises from inquiry.
 - ▶ Makes a specific, arguable claim.
 - ▶ Guides structure and evidence.
- Expect to revise it multiple times.
- Use feedback and reflection to sharpen the argument.
- Every paragraph should earn its place by advancing the thesis.
- Writing = continual **refinement of thought**.
- Different tasks have different goals
 - ▶ You must adjust your writing style to fit the goal
 - ▶ Different disciplines have different styles

Deduction and Induction in Practice

- **Deduction:** from accepted premises to a specific conclusion.
⇒ In real essays, premises are rarely beyond dispute—state them clearly.
- **Induction:** from specific data to generalization; always provisional.
⇒ Match claim strength to evidence quality and scope.
- Use both modes as needed; **hybrid** arguments are common.

Developing a Question or Problem

- Essays begin with a focused, arguable question.
- Good questions are:
 - ▶ Specific but open-ended
 - ▶ Grounded in evidence
 - ▶ Worth investigating
- Avoid merely factual or yes/no questions.
- Examples:
 - ▶ Weak: “Was Shakespeare popular?”
 - ▶ Strong: “How did Shakespeare’s use of rhetoric shape his political commentary?”

Thesis and Argument

- The **thesis** presents your central claim.
- An argument:
 - ▶ States a position clearly
 - ▶ Provides reasons and evidence
 - ▶ Anticipates counterarguments
- Strong theses are *debatable*, not descriptive.
- Structure builds logically from premise to conclusion.
- Each paragraph contributes to proving the thesis.

Evidence and Interpretation

- Evidence supports reasoning; interpretation connects evidence to claims.
- Types of evidence:
 - ▶ Textual quotation and analysis (Humanities)
 - ▶ Data, case studies, and surveys (Social Sciences)
- Avoid summary; explain significance.
- Analyze patterns and implications.
- Show how evidence leads logically to your conclusions.

Audience Awareness

- Write for an informed but critical audience.
- Assume readers understand the basics but not your interpretation.
- Provide context and define specialized terms.
- Anticipate objections and address them respectfully.
- Maintain an academic tone—formal but engaging.

Integrating Sources

- Use quotation, paraphrase, and summary effectively.
- Cite sources to:
 - ▶ Credit others' ideas
 - ▶ Strengthen your credibility
 - ▶ Help readers locate materials
- Follow the style your community uses — APA 7 in this course.
- Blend sources seamlessly with your own analysis.

Becoming a Scholar

- Writing transforms students into active participants in knowledge creation.
- Scholars:
 - ▶ Read critically
 - ▶ Write reflectively
 - ▶ Engage ethically with others' ideas
- Cultivate curiosity and persistence.
- Scholarship is a shared, evolving conversation.

Writing Across Disciplines

- **Humanities:** build an argument through interpretation.
→ *Thesis-driven essay*: claim, evidence, counterargument.
- **Social Sciences:** explain social phenomena systematically.
→ *IMRaD structure*: *Introduction* → *Methods* → *Results* → *Discussion*.
- **Linguistics:** mix of humanities and science.
→ *Intro* → *Background* → *Data/Methods* → *Analysis* → *Discussion* → *Conclusion*.
- **Computer Science:** emphasize reproducibility and innovation.
→ *Intro* → *Related Work* → *Method* → *Data* → *Experiments/Results* → *Analysis* → *Conclusion*.
- **Hybrids:** combine approaches (e.g., literature review + case study; policy analysis + recommendations).